

EGGPLANTS *Solanum melongena*

Also known as “aubergine” or “brinjal,” these variable fruits come in a wide range of shapes, sizes, and colors. They are easy to grow but won’t do well in cold conditions and will be killed by frost; in cool regions, they are best in a greenhouse. Although young plants are widely sold and are a good choice for gardeners without the warm conditions needed to raise seedlings, a wider range of varieties are offered as seed.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Sow seed in late winter or early spring, ensuring a minimum temperature of between 64–77°F (18–25°C). For optimum growth, seedlings need ample warmth and light and must not get crowded. Plant them out into individual containers as soon as possible.

Before transplanting, enrich soil, indoors or out, by digging in a 2 in (5 cm) layer of rotted organic matter and, in addition, in poor soils apply a generous amount of a balanced fertilizer. A warm, sheltered, sunny site is essential outdoors, and young seedlings may need protection with a cloche or a layer of horticultural fleece. Eggplants thrive in containers,



Plant out seedlings after hardening off.

and fruit set is often enhanced if these are not too large.

CROP CARE

During growth, pinch out the growing tips to induce bushy growth. Plants can produce large numbers of fruits, so support them with string and stakes to prevent damage. Plants are self-pollinating and do not require any assistance to set fruits.